

ONIONS *Allium cepa*

For a low-maintenance crop, try growing onions. They are raised from seed or from sets, which are specially produced mini-bulbs. Aside from fertile soil and routine care, onions just need plenty of time to mature. If you want large bulbs, be prepared to wait. There are various onion cultivars available—most have brown or golden-yellow skins, but red-skinned onions are also popular and have a milder flavor.

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
PLANT				
HARVEST				

SOWING

Onions need an open, well-drained site and non-acid soil. Dig in compost before sowing. To grow large onions, sow seed in midwinter in a heated greenhouse at 50–60°F (10–16°C) and harden off the seedlings in spring for planting out. For smaller bulbs, sow later in the winter or in early spring, under cover but without heat. When the weather warms up, you can sow seed directly into the soil, at about .75 in (2 cm) depth, in rows 12 in (30 cm) apart.

PLANTING

For a late summer or fall harvest, plant sets in spring. Push them into the soil, 2–4 in (5–10 cm) apart, depending on size, and cover, leaving the tips showing.



Dry onions thoroughly before storing.

CROP CARE

When planted-out seedlings are well established, thin them out according to the size of onion you want—closely planted onions are more likely to be smaller on harvest. Water both seedlings and sets moderately, since overwatering can delay swelling of the bulbs, and may make them more susceptible to disease. Weed the onion bed regularly.